with his enlightenment, his first sermon, and the aftermath of his demise. A symbol that now gained popularity to denote the Buddha was what Ashoka had donated at Mahabodhi—the majestic stone throne known as the vajrasana.[15] A sculptural relief on a pillar at Bharhut shows the Bodhi tree with the vajrasana in front. An identifying epigraph alludes to 'the building round the Bodhi tree of the holy Sakamuni'. The vajrasana is recognizable because of its monumental size, its slab and four supporting pilasters making it look somewhat similar to how it appears today. The relief also shows a pillar with a bell-shaped capital bearing the figure of an elephant, which could well be the sculptor's remembrance of an Ashokan specimen.[16] Similarly, the pillared religious sanctuary depicted here—the building mentioned in the inscription—was possibly the temple that Ashoka is said to have constructed at Mahabodhi.

The emperor himself is absent from the Buddhist iconography at Bharhut. This is not because rulers do not figure in such iconography. They do: rulers such as Pasenadi of Kosala and Ajatashatru of Magadha do appear, but these were monarchs who happened to be contemporaries of the Buddha.[17] It would take a couple of centuries for Ashoka to be similarly imaged. Eventually, he came to be remembered in this form in the early part of the first century CE on sculpted columns and lintels of the remarkable gateways which were set up at the four entrances to the stupas at Sanchi. There was, however, one major difference. Unlike Bharhut, where labels identify the kings, no identifying epigraphs accompany the figures depicted at Sanchi—neither those relating to incidents in the life of the Buddha nor to those of his patron Ashoka nor even to mythical characters from old tales and legends. Identifications have been subsequent, worked out on the basis of the subject matter of reliefs which follow the textual narratives of Buddhist stories. So, Ashoka's presence on them is based on correlations made between sculpture and story. Scholars centrally involved in the conservation and documentation of the wonderful narrative friezes at